

INDIA AND THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION → GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD → ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN → NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON → CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER → DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g2 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION COUNT

NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION COUNT LAND OR MARITIME BORDER PAKISTAN, CHINA, NEPAL, BHUTAN, BANGLADESH MYANMAR, SRI LANKA, MALDIVES AFGHANISTAN, ADJACENT AFTER PAKISTAN'S 1948 CAPTURE OF A STRIP FRICTION RECORD A HISTORY OF PROBLEMS WITH SIX OF THE EIGHT

NEIGHBOURHOOD IS DEFINED BY SECURITY RELEVANCE, NOT ONLY BY

LAND OR MARITIME BORDER → Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh

Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Maldives

NEAR-NEIGHBOUR → Afghanistan, adjacent after Pakistan's 1948 capture of a strip of north-western Kashmir

FRICTION RECORD → a history of problems with six of the eight bordering states

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- LAND OR MARITIME BORDER → Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh,
- Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Maldives

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NEAR-NEIGHBOUR → Afghanistan, adjacent after Pakistan's 1948 capture of a strip of north-western Kashmir
- FRICTION RECORD → a history of problems with six of the eight bordering states

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- RULE → neighbourhood is defined by security relevance, not only by contiguity
- LAND OR MARITIME BORDER → Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh,

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → neighbourhood is defined by security relevance, not only by contiguity.

01

STAGE 01 GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD

GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD PRINCIPLE 1 NO RECIPROCITY SOUGHT FROM SMALLER NEIGHBOURS PRINCIPLE 2 NO INTERFERENCE IN THEIR INTERNAL AFFAIRS PRINCIPLE 3 INDIAN TERRITORY NOT TO BE USED AGAINST THEM PRINCIPLE 4

PRINCIPLE 1 → no reciprocity sought from smaller neighbours

PRINCIPLE 2 → no interference in their internal affairs

PRINCIPLE 3 → Indian territory not to be used against them

PRINCIPLE 4 → respect for their territorial integrity

DATED OFFICIAL INSTRUMENT

- PRINCIPLE 1 → no reciprocity sought from smaller neighbours
- PRINCIPLE 2 → no interference in their internal affairs

EVIDENTIARY LEVEL IT REACHES

- PRINCIPLE 3 → Indian territory not to be used against them
- PRINCIPLE 4 → respect for their territorial integrity

STATUS / CLAIM LIMIT

- PRINCIPLE 5 → bilateral and peaceful settlement of disputes
- DEFINING FEATURE → non-reciprocal accommodation, never reciprocity as a precondition

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DEFINING FEATURE → non-reciprocal accommodation, never reciprocity as a precondition.

02

STAGE 02 ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN

ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN SIZE ASYMMETRY INDIA LARGER THAN THE ENTIRE IMMEDIATE NEIGHBOURHOOD COMBINED DEPENDENCE ANXIETY SMALLER STATES PREFER REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK ENGAGEMENT NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION THE DOCTRINE ANSWERS THE ANXIETY DIRECTLY

CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT

SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly

CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined
- DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly
- CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government
- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government.

03

STAGE 03 NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON SMALLER STATES BHUTAN, NEPAL, MALDIVES, SRI LANKA; GREATER INTEREST IN ECONOMIC LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX PAKISTAN AND BANGLADESH; MORE BILATERAL POSTURE; DISTINCT SECURITY AND REGIONAL PREFERENCE IS REASSURANCE, NOT A REJECTION OF BILATERAL

03

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined
- DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly
- CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government
- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government.

04

STAGE 03

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

SMALLER STATES

BHUTAN, NEPAL, MALDIVES, SRI LANKA; GREATER INTEREST IN ECONOMIC

LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX

PAKISTAN AND BANGLADESH; MORE BILATERAL POSTURE; DISTINCT SECURITY AND

REGIONAL PREFERENCE IS REASSURANCE, NOT A REJECTION OF BILATERAL

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka	regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security	QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
greater interest in economic integration	LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics	SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka
- greater interest in economic integration

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security
- LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
- SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery.

05

STAGE 04

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

1 NOVEMBER 2023

AKHAURA-AGARTALA CROSS-BORDER RAIL LINK INAUGURATED

BBIN MOTOR VEHICLES AGREEMENT SIGNED; BHUTAN NON-RATIFICATION CONSTRAINS IT

720 MW MANGDECHHU COMMISSIONED, THEN HANDED OVER TO BHUTAN

MAY 2023

KALADAN WATERWAY AND SITTWE PORT OPERATIONALISED; ROAD COMPONENT LAGGED

1 JUNE 2026

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated	2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan	1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it	MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged	RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ACTOR / INTEREST

- 1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated
- 2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- 2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan
- MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
- RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed.

06

STAGE 05

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

SRI LANKA

SEVEN MOUS, 5 APRIL 2025; BRIEF CURRENT TO JULY

JOINT VISION 7 OCTOBER 2024; FTA TERMS OF REFERENCE

INR 4,850 CRORE LINE OF CREDIT; BRIEF CURRENT TO

INR 100 BILLION FOR THE 13TH FIVE YEAR PLAN

2025; GELEPHU MINDFULNESS CITY SUPPORT 12 NOVEMBER 2025

VISION, TERMS OF REFERENCE, MEMORANDUM AND CREDIT ARE PRE-DELIVERY

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning	INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026	2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025
MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025	BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September	LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning
- MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026
- BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025
- LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments.

STAGE 06

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

BY 3 MAY 2022

MORE THAN USD 3 BILLION RECORDED IN ASSISTANCE DURING

USD 1 BILLION

FACILITY FOR FOOD, MEDICINES AND ESSENTIALS

USD 500 MILLION

PETROLEUM CREDIT LINE; CLOSE TO 400,000 TONNES OF FUEL

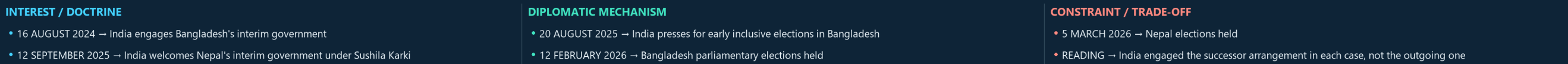
ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
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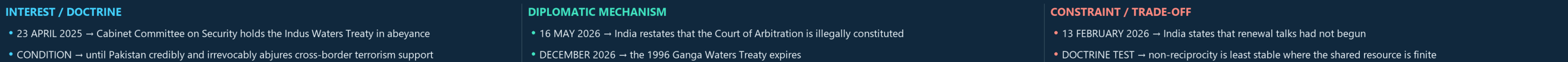
- LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

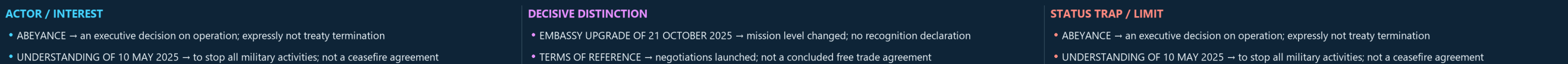
12 FEBRUARY 2026



DECEMBER 2026



EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025



09

STAGE 09 STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS

STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS AN EXECUTIVE DECISION ON OPERATION; EXPRESSLY NOT TREATY TERMINATION UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 TO STOP ALL MILITARY ACTIVITIES; NOT A CEASEFIRE AGREEMENT EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025

MISSION LEVEL CHANGED; NO RECOGNITION DECLARATION TERMS OF REFERENCE NEGOTIATIONS LAUNCHED; NOT A CONCLUDED FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination	EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration	ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement	TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement	UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement
ACTOR / INTEREST • ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination • UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement	DECISIVE DISTINCTION • EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration • TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT • ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination • UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

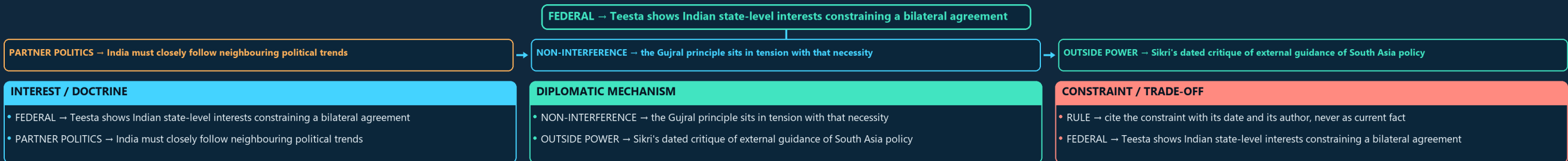
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement.

10

STAGE 10 DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND

DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND TEESTA SHOWS INDIAN STATE-LEVEL INTERESTS CONSTRAINING A BILATERAL AGREEMENT PARTNER POLITICS INDIA MUST CLOSELY FOLLOW NEIGHBOURING POLITICAL TRENDS THE GUJRAL PRINCIPLE SITS IN TENSION WITH THAT NECESSITY OUTSIDE POWER

SIKRI'S DATED CRITIQUE OF EXTERNAL GUIDANCE OF SOUTH ASIA CITE THE CONSTRAINT WITH ITS DATE AND ITS AUTHOR



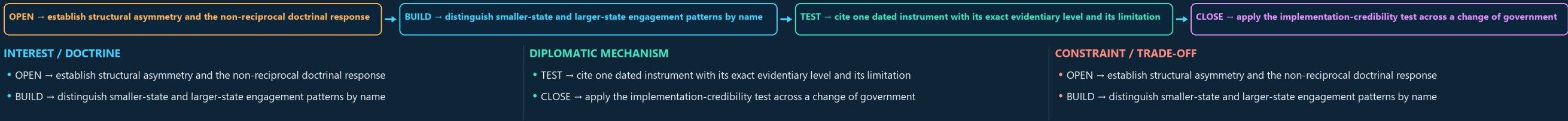
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the constraint with its date and its author, never as current fact.

11

STAGE 11 ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND ESTABLISH STRUCTURAL ASYMMETRY AND THE NON-RECIPROCAL DOCTRINAL RESPONSE DISTINGUISH SMALLER-STATE AND LARGER-STATE ENGAGEMENT PATTERNS BY NAME CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT WITH ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL

APPLY THE IMPLEMENTATION-CREDIBILITY TEST ACROSS A CHANGE OF GOVERNMENT



ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT BILATERAL SUMMIT-LEVEL MECHANISMS (ANNUAL OR PERIODIC LEADER-LEVEL) MEA BILATERAL BRIEFS (INDIA-SRI LANKA AND INDIA-BHUTAN, CURRENT TO) POWER-GRID AND TRANSIT PROTOCOLS ARE TYPICALLY NEGOTIATED AND RENEWED

REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK OVERLAY (SAARC, BIMSTEC) PROVIDES THE MULTILATERAL BOUNDARY CASE — HISTORICAL INTERVENTION VS. STATED NON-INTERFERENCE BOUNDARY CASE — SMALLER-STATE HEDGING EVEN NEIGHBOURS THAT VALUE

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE AND INSTRUMENT DEPTH

- CAUTION: Bilateral summit-level mechanisms (annual or periodic leader-level)
- MEA bilateral briefs (India-Sri Lanka and India-Bhutan, current to July)
- CAUTION: Power-grid and transit protocols are typically negotiated and renewed
- CAUTION: Regional-framework overlay (SAARC, BIMSTEC) provides the multilateral

STATUS, DATE AND FIGURE LIMIT

- CAUTION: Boundary case — historical intervention vs. stated non-interference:
- CAUTION: Boundary case — smaller-state hedging: even neighbours that value
- CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan as a near-neighbour: Tharoor's inclusion of
- CAUTION: Regime change discontinuity risk: any government transition in a

COMPARATIVE DIPLOMATIC NUANCE

- CAUTION: Boundary case — the implementation-credibility test with dated
- CAUTION: Non-reciprocity has fiscal and political cost: the Gujral Doctrine's
- CAUTION: Regional-framework preference vs. bilateral delivery tension: smaller
- CAUTION: Domestic political engagement vs. non-interference principle: the need

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.